Responding to Incidents with Pets

Guidance for handling pet-related issues at shelters, including pet owners struggling to care for their pet, injured or sick animals, animal fights and animal bites

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager, Shelter Workers, Pet Shelter Services Field Team Members
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, Mass Care Chief

Considerations

- Pets often experience stress at shelters and may behave in ways they would not at home.
- Owners may struggle to support their pets in an unfamiliar environment with limited resources.
- Avoid using words such as “aggressive,” “dangerous,” or “bad” which may anger pet owners and not accurately describe the animal.
- Related **Mass Care Groups Standards**
  - Initiating Mass Care Services
  - Prioritizing Mass Care Services
  - Mass Care Service Site Requirements
- Related **Sheltering Activity Standards**
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

Supporting a pet owner who is struggling to care for their pet

- If a client is struggling to take care of their pet, talk with them to determine what challenges they are facing and what might help them.
- If a pet appears distressed (example behaviors: excessive barking, licking, or moving) inform the animal welfare partner.
- Support the owner in a sensitive and compassionate way.
  - As needed, coordinate with *Disaster Health Services* or *Disaster Mental Health Services* sections to explore the challenges and potential solutions.
  - Work with animal welfare partner to explore how they can support the pet and its owner.

Supporting sick and injured pets

- If you notice or a client informs you that their pet is sick or injured, immediately seek support from the animal welfare partner (with owner’s consent).
- If no animal welfare partner is present at shelter, refer the client to an emergency veterinary resource provided by the animal welfare partner or the *HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator.*
- If no veterinary partner has been identified, work with *External Relations section* to identify one.

Responding to animal fights

- If a pet attacks another pet, immediately instruct the owners to separate the pets and move with their pet in opposite directions, preferably out of the view of the other animal(s).
- The Shelter Site Manager must speak with both pet owners and reinforce pet policies.
- When both pets are injured in the fight support the owners with finding prompt veterinary care.

- When only one animal is injured, support the owner in seeking veterinary care for the injured pet and isolate the other animal.
    - Seek and follow veterinarian and/or animal welfare partner guidance to support the uninjured animal.

- Record the incident in SCIA by recording the details as a comment in SCIA.
- Make any additional referrals that the client needs.
    - For example: the owners may want or need a referral to talk with Disaster Mental Health and/or Disaster Spiritual Care

Pet bites a person at the shelter

- Immediately isolate the animal by placing it in a crate provided by owner or the animal welfare partner.
- Promptly request assistance from Emergency Medical Services or Disaster Health Services to address injury.
    - If the bite is serious the injured individual should seek prompt medical attention (hospital or urgent care center).

- Confirm the status of the pet's rabies vaccination.
- Notifications and documentation
    - Shelter Site Manager must document the incident in the Shelter Manager Log and completes any animal bite forms required by local/state government.
    - The Shelter Site Manager or HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator must contact the Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) and the Disaster Health Services HQ Manager the local Health Department to report bite.
    - Shelter Site Manager and/or Pet Services Field Team member notify the HQ Sheltering Manager and the HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator of the incident.

- Shelter staff follow directions provided by the animal Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) and/or Health Department.
    - The local Agency Having Jurisdiction (AHJ) works directly with this pet owner to inform them of any next steps.

Pet Surrenders/Relinquish Ownership

- If a household states they wish/need to surrender or relinquish ownership of their pet be compassionate and kind.
- Inform the animal welfare partner, the HQ Pet Services Coordinator and HQ Sheltering Manager, who can explore alternatives to prevent surrender.
    - Immediate action must be taken if owner is no longer at shelter and has abandoned animal by informing the animal welfare partner immediately.

- No member of the Red Cross workforce is to take custody of a pet.
- Any interest in adoption or fostering must be coordinated with the Animal Welfare Partner.

Related Articles

Pet Shelter Services Intent
Executive/High-Level Overview of the Pet Shelter Services which provides support to households with pets that are checked into Red Cross shelters.

Pet Sheltering Requirements
Physical requirements and procedures for co-located and cohabitated pet sheltering

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Questions